

Claiming Her

*The Difference Between Curiosity,
Identity and Commitment*



Blessing Sonia Benjoye

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Commitment*

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Dedication

To me for the years of silence, confusion and isolation, for the courage to finally see myself clearly and claim who I am.

And to every woman who has felt different, alone, or unseen may this book remind you that your truth is yours to own, quietly, boldly, and without apology.

Acknowledgments

I want to acknowledge the women who taught me what it means to live authentically even when the world tells you not to.

I am grateful for the moments of silence that forced me to look inward and the moments of courage that allowed me to finally see myself clearly.

Thank you to the friends and mentors who offered support, guidance, and wisdom along this journey. Your presence, even when quiet, mattered more than you know.

And most of all, I honor my own journey the years of confusion, self doubt, and discovery that led me here. This book exists because I chose to claim myself.

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Introduction

Growing up, I always knew there was something different about me, something I could not fully name. I was raised in a Christian home, surrounded by rules, expectations, and a clear picture of what it meant to be a woman in the world around me. I was expected to like men, to date them, to imagine a life built that way.

But I did not.

For years, I lived in quiet confusion. I did not experiment. I did not fit the mold. I did not hide completely, but I did not speak openly either. I spent a long time alone, feeling the weight of expectation and the clarity of my own truth at the same time. I could not deny what I felt, I was not attracted to the opposite gender but understanding myself fully, claiming who I truly am, came much later.

This book is about that journey. It is about curiosity, identity, and commitment. It is about the difference between wanting, knowing, and choosing. It is about the moment when you stop questioning and start claiming yourself, even quietly, even carefully, even when the world around you may not understand.

I wrote this book for myself, and for every woman who has felt different, unseen, or misunderstood. It is for those who are learning to live authentically in a world that often refuses to make space for them. It is not a guide, and it is not a manifesto. It is a reflection, a conversation, a record of claiming myself and by doing so, opening a space for others to consider claiming themselves as well.

The pages that follow are my story, my reflections, and the lessons I have drawn from years of self observation, struggle, and quiet celebration. It is my hope that in reading this, you might recognize your own curiosity, confront your own identity, and find the courage to commit to yourself fully.

Part I: Curiosity – The Confusion

Curiosity is the first spark. It is the quiet, restless noticing that something about you does not fit the world around you. It is the tension between what you feel and what you are expected to feel. This part of the book is about that early awareness, the questions, the isolation, and the beginnings of understanding that would eventually lead to claiming myself fully.

Chapter 1: Not Like the Others

From as early as I can remember, I knew I was different. I did not understand it fully, and I could not name it, but I felt it in everything I experienced. Growing up in a Christian household in Africa, the rules were clear. Girls were meant to like boys. Girls were meant to imagine lives built with men, to date them, to fall in love with them, and to aspire to the roles society had prepared

I did not feel any of that.

I noticed my peers talking about boys with excitement, curiosity, and desire, but I could not relate. I could not imagine it. I did not hide from it entirely, but I also did not speak about it. It was something quiet inside me, something I carried alone. I would sometimes wonder if there was something wrong with me. Maybe it was a phase. Maybe I was broken.

And yet, even in that confusion, there was certainty. I knew I was not attracted to the opposite gender. I knew it deep inside, though I could not name it yet. That certainty was my first contact with the self I would eventually come to claim.

Curiosity kept me awake in those years. I watched, I questioned, I reflected. I wondered about myself, about desire, and about the life I might have if I could be honest. I did not experiment. I did not act. I simply observed the world, the rules, and myself.

This was the beginning of understanding. It was the first chapter of claiming myself, even before I knew what claiming truly meant. It was the start of seeing that identity and commitment were separate from curiosity, and that knowing myself would take years of quiet reflection, patience, and courage.

Chapter 2: Alone, But Not Lost

For a long time, I was alone. Not because I wanted to be, but because the world I lived in did not make space for who I was. I did not date men, could not imagine intimacy with them, and could not explain why. I watched others move through their lives in pairs, in expectation, in rhythm with society's plan, while I felt out of step.

But being alone did not mean I was lost. In fact, it was in that solitude that I began to notice myself. I began to feel the quiet contours of my own desires, the edges of my own identity, and the pull of a truth I had yet to name. Alone, I could observe without judgment. Alone, I could reflect without interference. Alone, I could be honest with myself in ways the world would not allow.

There were moments of doubt. There were nights when I wondered if something was wrong with me. Was I broken? Was I missing something essential? And yet, underneath all that questioning, there was a deeper certainty: I was not attracted to the opposite gender. That truth, small and steady, became my anchor.

Being alone taught me patience. It taught me that claiming yourself does not begin with other people. It begins with understanding your own heart. It begins with sitting quietly in your own company and realizing that solitude is not a punishment, but a classroom.

It was in this space, in these years of quiet reflection, that I began to recognize the difference between curiosity and identity. Curiosity asks questions. Identity begins to answer them. And commitment comes later, when you choose yourself fully, when you decide to live according to your own truth.

Alone, I was learning to see myself. Alone, I was learning to be unshakable in my own quiet certainty. Alone, I was not lost. I was beginning.

Chapter 3: The Silent Compass

There were moments when I felt lost, even though I was certain of one thing: I was not like the others. Growing up, I would watch my peers follow the expected paths dating boys, talking about crushes, imagining the lives they were “supposed” to live and I felt a quiet dissonance.

It was in these moments of quiet observation that I discovered my first compass. Not one written in rules or religious texts, not one imposed by family or society, but a silent compass that guided me toward truth. It was subtle, almost imperceptible at times. A flutter of certainty when I thought about other women. A discomfort, almost nausea, when I imagined myself with men. Small feelings, easily overlooked, yet impossible to ignore once I paid attention.

I remember one Sunday, sitting in church, surrounded by expectations sermons about marriage, the future, “your God given husband.” I felt a disconnect so deep that it made my chest ache. I tried to pray the right prayers, to imagine the “correct” life, but my heart refused to follow. That day, alone in the pew, I began to listen more carefully to that silent compass.

Curiosity, at that point, was not about experimenting or acting. It was about noticing, observing, and quietly questioning. I began to catalog my feelings, to pay attention to the small things: the people who drew my gaze, the stories that made me feel alive, the moments that unsettled me. Slowly, over years, this quiet noticing became a map imperfect, sometimes confusing, but always pointing me toward myself.

Being guided by this silent compass was not easy. It required patience. It required courage to stay true even when the world did not understand. It required the willingness to be alone without losing oneself in loneliness. And it required trust: trust that if I paid attention to my own truth, I would eventually find my way.

By the end of these years, I realized that curiosity is never simple. It is messy, contradictory, and patient. It asks questions without always offering answers. But when paired with honesty and reflection, curiosity becomes a tool, a guide, a silent compass that prepares you for identity and, eventually, commitment.

Part II: Identity – Becoming

Identity is the next stage. It is the moment when curiosity transforms into recognition. When the silent compass has pointed you toward yourself long enough, you begin to see who you truly are. This part is about the journey of naming yourself, seeing your reflection clearly, and understanding the depth of your own truth.

Chapter 4: The Mirror of Truth

It was only when I allowed myself to look closely, really closely, that I began to see. For years I had lived in quiet awareness, observing the world and my own feelings without judgment. But seeing myself meant more than noticing difference. It meant confronting it, naming it, and acknowledging it without fear.

I remember the moment it first became clear. I was alone in my apartment one evening, a quiet night after a day full of expectation and small social performances. I looked in the mirror and for the first time asked myself, with honesty, who I was, who I had always been. The answer did not come in words, not immediately. It came as a feeling, a certainty that spread through me and settled deep inside.

I was not just different. I was myself.

The mirror reflected not only my face, but the truth I had avoided naming. It showed me the contradictions I had lived with for years faith and desire, expectation and longing, solitude and courage. It showed me the patterns, the choices, the moments where I had already claimed pieces of myself without even realizing it.

Seeing myself clearly was not easy. It brought discomfort, because the world outside the mirror did not understand, and because I had been taught to suppress this part of me. But in that reflection, I found a quiet joy, a sense of alignment that no external validation could provide.

Identity is never simple. It is layered, complex, and sometimes frightening. But seeing yourself, naming yourself, is the first act of true freedom. It is the beginning of living according to your own truth, rather than the expectations of others. The mirror does not lie, and it does not demand perfection. It simply shows you, fully, and waits for you to recognize and accept what you see.

Chapter 5: Between Faith and Desire

Faith shaped my life from the very beginning. It taught me what was right and wrong, who I was supposed to be, and how the world expected me to move through it. It gave me comfort, structure, and a sense of belonging. And yet, it also revealed the distance between who I was expected to be and who I felt myself to be.

Desire began as a quiet, almost unnoticeable awareness. I felt it tugging at my thoughts, my heart, my curiosity. But I could not name it, could not fully understand it, and certainly could not reconcile it with the life I had been taught to live. I wondered: could I ever accept this part of myself and still remain faithful? Could I serve God and still honor the truth I felt inside?

For a long time, I tried to find answers in prayer. I asked for guidance, for clarity, for peace. I wanted to understand myself without feeling as though I was betraying my faith. I wanted to reconcile the expectations of my upbringing with the reality of my inner life.

I began to see that faith and desire were not necessarily in opposition. Desire was not a rejection of my beliefs; it was a part of me that required reflection, honesty, and patience. Faith was not an obstacle to self understanding; it was a guide, a reminder of the values I wanted to carry forward as I explored my truth.

In this chapter of my life, I had not yet claimed myself fully. I was learning to listen to my heart without judgment, to pay attention to the signals of my own truth, and to reconcile them with the life I wanted to live. This was the work of patience, courage, and reflection.

Between faith and desire, I was navigating a delicate path. I was still questioning, still exploring, still searching. But I was also beginning to trust that one day, I would be able to recognize, name, and accept myself fully and that my faith would remain a part of me throughout that journey.

Chapter 6: Naming Herself

After years of reflection, observation, and quiet questioning, the moment came when I could no longer avoid the truth. I had spent so long wondering, analyzing, and reconciling faith and desire, trying to understand myself without naming it. But now, finally, I could.

Naming myself was not about rebellion or defiance. It was about honesty. It was about acknowledging the reality I had felt all along the desire, the attraction, the truth of who I am. I could finally say to myself, This is me. This is who I have always been.

It was a quiet recognition at first. I did not shout it to the world. I did not need to. Naming myself was an inward act, a declaration to my own heart. I looked at myself clearly, accepted the parts of me I had once questioned, and allowed myself to feel the relief of truth fully.

This naming did not change my faith, nor did it distance me from God. In fact, it strengthened my connection to what I believed. Accepting myself allowed me to live with integrity, authenticity, and honesty qualities that my faith had always valued. I realized that being true to myself and being faithful were not separate paths. They were intertwined.

I also began to notice how much freedom comes from recognition. Once you can name yourself, the choices in your life become clearer. You understand the boundaries, the desires, the direction you want to move in. The uncertainty that once weighed heavily on me began to lift, replaced by quiet confidence.

Naming myself was more than recognition. It was the first real step in claiming my life. It was the bridge between who I had been and who I would become. And with that recognition, I could finally step into the next phase: living fully, deliberately, and committed to myself.

Part III: Commitment – Claiming

Commitment is the act of living what you have discovered. It is more than recognition. It is not enough to know who you are or to name it quietly to yourself. Commitment means making choices that honor your truth every day, even when the world does not understand.

Chapter 7: Choosing Self First

Choosing myself first was not easy. It went against every expectation I had grown up with, every assumption others had about who I should be, and even some of the fears I held about myself. But I realized that before I could love anyone else, before I could fully engage with the world, I had to be fully aligned with my own truth.

There were moments of doubt. There were moments when I wondered if prioritizing myself would feel selfish or lonely. And yet, each time I listened to that inner compass, I felt stronger, clearer, and more certain. Choosing myself was not about isolation. It was about integrity. It was about living authentically, in a way that reflected all I had discovered and claimed about myself.

I began to make decisions based on alignment with my truth rather than obligation, expectation, or fear. I stopped pretending to be someone I was not. I honored the boundaries that protected me and nurtured the parts of myself I had once ignored.

Choosing myself first was an act of courage. It was a declaration that my life, my desires, my identity, and my faith all mattered. And in doing so, I discovered something profound: the more I lived fully for myself, the more freely I could engage with others, love authentically, and serve the life I wanted to create.

Commitment is not a one-time decision. It is a practice, a daily choice to prioritize truth, honesty, and integrity. By choosing myself first, I was claiming the life I had always been meant to live, and stepping fully into the freedom that comes with it.

Chapter 8: Coded, But Not Silent

Living my truth in this world has never been about shouting it from rooftops. There are spaces where safety matters, where discretion is wisdom, and where the world is not yet ready to see you fully. Being coded does not mean being silent. It does not mean hiding. It means choosing how, when, and where to reveal the parts of yourself that are most vulnerable.

I learned to live in layers. There is the self the world expects, shaped by rules and assumptions. And there is the self I claim the truth of who I am, quietly known, deliberately nurtured. The coded self is intentional. It is protective. It allows me to move through the world safely while remaining unshakable in my identity.

Being coded taught me subtlety and resilience. I learned to speak in ways that carried meaning only to those who could understand. I learned to celebrate myself privately, to honor my desires discreetly, and to live fully without needing constant validation. This approach did not diminish my truth. If anything, it sharpened it. I became more aware of my boundaries, more deliberate in my choices, and more faithful to my own inner compass.

Living coded is not a compromise. It is strategy. It is a quiet revolution of self. I can be fully me authentic, proud, and committed without putting myself at unnecessary risk. I can exist in faith, in desire, and in love without losing my grounding.

The silence is not emptiness. It is a space of power, reflection, and clarity. It is the arena where commitment takes root, where identity is reinforced daily, and where the courage to live unapologetically grows. I am coded, but I am not silent.

Chapter 9: Love, Community, and Consequence

Living my truth has not been easy. For many of us, there is no safety net. There is no circle of family, no supportive community waiting to affirm you. Choosing authenticity often means choosing isolation. It means making peace with the fact that some people will never understand, and some will turn away entirely.

Love in this space is complicated. It is not the kind of love that is celebrated or publicly acknowledged. It is quiet, sometimes coded, sometimes hidden. It exists in the moments you allow yourself to feel it safely, in the relationships that survive despite fear or judgment. And it is fiercely precious, because it is real and hard-won.

Community is not always a comfort. Many of us have to navigate a world where spaces of belonging are scarce. Where friends might drift away, family might reject, and institutions even places of faith may condemn. In that reality, living authentically is an act of courage, even when done in solitude.

Consequence is ever present. Living your truth in a world that refuses to see it carries weight sometimes fear, sometimes loneliness, sometimes judgment. But it also carries clarity. You learn who you are when there is no applause, no validation, and no easy approval. You learn to stand for yourself quietly, to honor your own boundaries, and to live deliberately despite the absence of support.

This chapter of life is not about comfort or celebration. It is about survival, integrity, and quiet resilience. It is about claiming yourself fully, even when the world does not recognize you. It is about knowing that living authentically, with or without community, is not a failure. It is a commitment to yourself that no rejection can undo.

Chapter 10: Living the Thesis

All the years of curiosity, reflection, questioning, and self-discovery have led to this moment. Living the thesis is not a single event. It is not a grand announcement or a public declaration. It is the daily act of aligning your life with the truth you have claimed.

I live my life deliberately. I make choices that honor who I am, even when no one else understands. I move through the world carefully, aware of what I reveal and to whom. I am coded, but I am not silent. I am cautious, but I am unshakable in my identity.

Faith remains a guiding force. Accepting myself did not weaken my connection to God. If anything, it strengthened it. I worship fully, serve sincerely, and hold onto my beliefs while embracing my truth. I have learned that spirituality and self-acceptance are not opposed. They can coexist, support each other, and deepen the meaning of both.

Living the thesis also means recognizing the cost. There is isolation, the absence of support, the moments when the world seems hostile or indifferent. There is loneliness, and sometimes fear. But there is also clarity, integrity, and freedom. Living in alignment with yourself, even quietly, is a triumph that no external validation can match.

The thesis is not static. It grows with me. It evolves as I navigate relationships, faith, and desire. It is tested in solitude and strengthened by reflection. It is the ongoing practice of commitment to self, the conscious decision to live deliberately, and the courage to remain authentic regardless of consequence.

This is the culmination of curiosity, identity, and commitment. It is the life I have claimed, fully, quietly, and intentionally. It is my truth in action, my self in practice, and the living proof that even in the absence of support, even in coded spaces, even under scrutiny, it is possible to exist fully and unapologetically as who you are.

Epilogue: Quiet Revolution

Claiming yourself is never loud. It does not always make headlines. It does not always fit the expectations of society, family, or even faith communities. But it is revolutionary. Every choice you make to honor your truth, every quiet moment of reflection, every act of integrity is a statement the world may not see but that you, and only you, feel fully.

The revolution is quiet because it begins inside. It begins in the heart, in the moments when you choose honesty over fear, clarity over confusion, and courage over conformity. It is quiet because it is intimate, personal, and deeply felt. And yet, its impact is profound. Living authentically in a world that resists your truth reshapes how you experience life, love, faith, and freedom.

My journey has been one of curiosity, identity, and commitment. I have learned that curiosity is the spark that awakens self-awareness. Identity is the recognition that follows reflection and honesty. Commitment is the deliberate act of living your truth fully, even when the world offers no applause, support, or understanding.

This is a quiet revolution. It does not always happen in public, but it reshapes the way you move through the world. It teaches resilience, patience, and self-respect. It reminds you that the most important approval is your own.

To live authentically is to live courageously. To claim yourself is to enact a revolution that no one else can define or take away. And in that quiet, unwavering commitment to truth, you discover the freedom, clarity, and peace that comes from being unapologetically yourself.

About the Author

Blessing Sonia Benjoye is a writer whose work examines identity, desire, faith, and the tensions that shape a woman's inner life. Across her books, she explores the architecture of selfhood and the courage required to live authentically in worlds that demand conformity. *Claiming Her* continues this inquiry, tracing the path from curiosity through identity to commitment. Sonia writes with clarity, rigor, and precision, inviting readers into spaces of reflection that are intimate yet universally resonant.

Other Works by Sonia Benjoye

- Nothing Stays Hidden
- What It Took
- The Paradox of Passion
- Woman. Weapon. Work.
- This Is the Season for Guts
- God Was Never the Problem
- Mother. Monster. Machine.
- Black Veins, Open Mouth
- Her Hand Held the Future, Her Back Held the Weight
- The Beautiful Discipline of Boredom
- This Is How She Ended the World
- Blackout City
- Thrones Built On Sand